

A Muslim girl from a poverty-stricken family, Bi is paralysed below the waist. A resident of J.P. Nagar, she lives with her mother Sitara Bi in a slum which is opposite the now-defunct Union Carbide plant. Her mother is herself a victim of the gas disaster and doesn't know how long she will live. Sitara's elder daughter had died a month after the disaster while her husband who was also exposed to the toxic fumes, died in 1990. The family couldn't get compensation for Latif's death due to their inability to bribe their way through the maze of middlemen who dominated the claims courts.

a lot of speculation, a mysterious phone call from a higher-up to the then chief minister Arjun Singh. Anderson was flown back to Delhi on a state Government plane and immediately left India after meeting the then President Giani Zail Singh, never to return or face trial. Moti Singh, district magistrate of Bhopal in 1984 also claimed that instructions to give bail to Anderson came from the chief secretary of Madhya Pradesh. The revelation by B.R. Lall, the CBI joint director in the mid-90s, that he had received a written communique from the MEA not to push for Anderson's extradition isn't exactly a new expose. Justice S. Murlidhar back in 2005 had compiled a detailed report on the disaster, and noted that the Centre was indifferent in the matter and the attorney general for India had given two written opinions recommending that Anderson may not be extradited.

Mahindra is the most prominent accused in India but he too was a non-executive chairman and not directly involved in Carbide's day-to-day operations. The six other accused were di-

Disaster Strikes Again

December 3, 1984: Toxic MIC gas from Union Carbide plant kills over 15,000 and injures five lakh. Millions left sick and successive generations show harmful effects.

December 4, 1984: UC chairman Warren Anderson is arrested along with eight others. Freed on bail of \$2,000. UC is named as the 10th accused.

February, 1985: The Indian Government files claim for



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\$3.3 billion from UC in US court. **1986:** US District Court judge transfers all Bhopal litigation to India.

December 1987: CBI files chargesheet against Anderson and others, including UCC (USA), Union Carbide (Eastern) Hong Kong, and UCIL. Summons served on Anderson and UCC.

February 1989: Bhopal court issues non-bailable warrants against Anderson for repeatedly ignoring summons.

February 1989: Indian government and UC strike an out-of-court deal and compensation of \$470 million is given.

February-March 1989: Review and writ petitions filed in the

Supreme Court by NGOs.

February 1992: Part of \$470 million is disbursed among victims.

February 1992: Anderson declared a fugitive.

November 1994: The Supreme Court allows UC to sell stake in UCIL to McLeod Russell (India) Ltd., Calcutta.

September 1996: Supreme Court dilutes charges against Indian officials of UCIL.

August 1999: Union Carbide announces merger with US-based Dow Chemicals.

November 1999: Greenpeace finds toxic chemicals around UC factory.

November 1999: Victims file suit against UC and Anderson in federal court of New York.

February 2001: UC refuses to take responsibility for UCIL's liabilities.

January 2002: Toxics Links finds lead and mercury in breast milk of mothers living near the plant.

August 2002: Indian court maintains culpable homicide charges against Anderson. A UK newspaper reports that Anderson is in New York after US authorities are unable to locate him.

May 2003: India formally seeks Anderson's extradition.

March 2004: India forwards noc to US over cleaning of factory site by Dow Chemicals.

June 2004: The US rejects Anderson's extradition request.

October 26, 2004: Supreme Court sets November 15 deadline for paying \$470 million compensation.

July 22, 2009: Bhopal court issues new arrest warrant against Anderson. His trial is separated from others.

June 7, 2010: Local court declares all the eight accused guilty. They are freed on bail.